
The Compassion Course

2026 – 2027 · Participant Workbook

A year of practicing compassion, one week at a time.

THIS WORKBOOK BELONGS TO

Name	
Email	

How to Use This Workbook

This is your personal copy of The Compassion Course workbook — one private copy for each participant, opened from the link we send you. There is nothing to download, install, or back up. Just open your link and type your responses in the shaded boxes; your writing saves automatically and the boxes grow as you type. Please write only inside the boxes so your entries stay easy to find and review.

Certificate of Completion (COC)

Use this workbook to record and track your weekly progress through the course.

We will email you weekly reminders and helpful hints to keep you on track.

If you registered for the Certificate of Completion, please fill out every prompt.

At the end of the course year, a Compassion Course faculty member will confidentially confirm that you completed your work. This is a completion check — it does not include mentoring or feedback.

Completing your workbook is part of qualifying to become a Mentor the following year.

Week 1

Everything We Do, We Do to Meet a Need

Practice #1 — Learn About and Notice Needs

Keep a small journal with you throughout the day. Make 1 to 5 entries per day that include the description of an act or words spoken by someone and what need you imagine they were trying to meet. It is SUPER important to limit the words you use to those on the needs list. The reasons for doing this will become clearer in the coming weeks.

 Your response · Week 1 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Notice Needs — More Challenge

Think of someone who is close to you who is doing or saying something you don't like. See if you can figure out what need they are attempting to fulfill. Again, it is really important to limit the words you use to those on the needs list. Again, the reasons for doing this will become clearer in the coming weeks.

 Your response · Week 1 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — Join the Course's Global Compassion Network

Through the Global Compassion Network (GCN) we can stay in touch, 24/7. Through this vital platform, we create and nurture our global community with mutual experience, support and growth (details are below).

Join the Global Compassion Network →

 Your response · Week 1 · Practice #3

Practice #4 — Consider Sharing the Course with Someone Who is Important to You

As you may imagine, the course can help us in our relationships with our friends, family, loved ones, co-workers, and partners, to name a few. When we take the course together it gives us a shared set of powerful, practical skills and tools to connect — often like never before.

Extended registration lasts for one week. To let someone know about the course you can use the following link: www.compassioncourse.org.

 Your response · Week 1 · Practice #4

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 2

Most Of Us Were Taught Something Else

Practice #1 — Noticing and Translating Judgments in Oneself

Keep a small journal with you throughout the day. Make 1 to 5 entries per day that include judgment words you said or were thinking of saying. Later on, when you have time, sit down with the needs list and see if you can figure out what need of yours the judgment was (or is) related to. Remember, to successfully complete this exercise, limit the words you use to those on the needs list.

 Your response · Week 2 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Noticing and Translating Judgments by Others

Keep a small journal with you throughout the day. It could be a little book, a folded piece of paper or a napkin -anything you can write on. Make 1 to 5 entries per day that include judgment words spoken by someone. Later on, when you have time, sit down with the needs list and see if you can figure out what need was unmet for them. Remember to limit the words you use to those on the needs list.

 Your response · Week 2 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — Judgment Liberation

Think of someone you have held a judgment about for a long time (more than 12 weeks). See if you can figure out what unmet need of yours might be associated with this judgment. In other words, what need of yours that you would like to have met, is not met in your relationship with this person? Then, see if you can think of 3 ways you might meet this need (that may or may not include the person the judgment is about).

 Your response · Week 2 · Practice #3

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 3

We Are All Equipped with Onboard Need Radar

Practice #1 — Notice Feelings

Keep a small journal with you throughout the day. This can be a small notebook or even a folded piece of paper. Make 2 to 4 entries per day that include something that someone else did or said and the feeling (or feelings) you experienced at that moment.

Later on, when you have time, sit down with the feelings list and see if you can find a similar feeling word from the list that describes how you were feeling. Give the list a thorough looking over. See if there are other words that reflect your experience as well.

NOTE: If you are going to complete this practice effectively, it is imperative that you read the "Big Hint" at the top of the feelings list.

Then look at the needs list and see if you can figure out what need your feeling was about. Remember, it's VERY helpful to limit the words you use to those on the needs list.

🗍 Your response · Week 3 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Notice More Feelings

Keep a small journal with you throughout the day. Make 2 to 4 entries per day that include something you did, said or were thinking of saying and the feeling (or feelings) you experienced at that moment. Again, later on, when you have time, sit down with the feelings list and see if you can find feeling words from the list that describe how you were feeling. Again, give the list a thorough looking over. See if there are other words that reflect your experience as well.

NOTE: If you are going to complete this practice effectively, it is imperative that you read the "Big Hint" at the top of the feelings list.

Then look at the needs list and see if you can figure out what need your feeling was about. Remember, here too, it's VERY important to limit the words you use to those on the needs list.

🗍 Your response · Week 3 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 4

What's the Big Deal with Needs?

Practice #1 — Read the needs list.

Notice what comes up in you as you do this.

🔍 Your response · Week 4 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Print a copy of the needs list.

Then, along the left side of each need word, write down a rating on a scale of 1-10 in terms of how well it is met in your life. (1 = hardly met at all and 10 = very met).

Use the interactive sliders below for a few core needs:

🔍 Your response · Week 4 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — More Noticing Needs - Renew from Week 1

Keep a small journal with you throughout the day. Make 1 to 5 entries per day that include an act or words spoken by someone and what need(s) you imagine they were trying to meet. Remember, it's VERY helpful to limit the words you use to those on the needs list.

🔍 Your response · Week 4 · Practice #3

Practice #4 — Liberation Exercise #2

Think of someone that you think is preventing you from getting a need(s) met. Write down the need(s) from the needs list. Then, think of 3 ways you could get them/it met without that person. It helps to use your imagination a bit here too. It might also be fun and inspiring to share your results on our CCO 2024 Participant Forum or in the Weekly Messages Chat Room, on the GCN

🔍 Your response · Week 4 · Practice #4

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 5

Empathy, the Breath of Compassion

Practice #1 — Review the "Shifting Toward Compassion" exercise

Visit: <http://theexercise.org> once or twice (or more times).

Your response · Week 5 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Increasing Awareness

Keep a small journal with you throughout the day. Make 1 to 5 entries per day that include the description of an action done or words spoken by someone (yourself included) and what feelings and what needs you think could have been present.

For this particular exercise, choose "uneventful" moments, NOT a moment of upset. Look for more subtle occurrences: someone calling to their child, someone saying "excuse me", you saying "thank you" to someone and so on.

Many of us wait until we're "hit over the head" with a situation before we start our practice of awareness. This practice helps us increase our awareness of feelings and needs by proactively noticing them in more subtle situations.

This practice also helps us see that these energies (feelings and needs) are everywhere.

If you haven't already, [Click Here to Join the GCN](#)

Your response · Week 5 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 6

Hidden Judgments

Practice #1 — "Shifting towards Compassion"

Continue working with this exercise (www.theexercise.org). This time, start using observations in addition to quotes, such as actions. You can also work with your own judgment thoughts by writing the words "I'm telling myself ____". For example "I'm telling myself Chris is selfish".

 Your response · Week 6 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Experiencing Judgments versus Needs

Write down 4 judgments you have about your own needs (for example, "I don't deserve to have them", "they are a sign of weakness" - take your time). Next, view or print a copy of the needs list. Then, choose your top 5 favorite needs (for that moment) and write them down. Scan and ponder your lists. Notice how you feel as you "take in" these two different lists. You may want to share this on one of our Community Forums.

 Your response · Week 6 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — Non-Feeling Word Game

This simple game or exercise was inspired by the many hours I spent in dentist's and doctor's waiting rooms reading children's magazines, "connecting the dots". It is a practice in finding "hidden judgments" and "unpacking" the feelings and needs inside them. [Click here to play.](#)

 Your response · Week 6 · Practice #3

Practice #4 — Heavier Lifting

Distinguishing Evaluations and Judgments - This exercise helps us find the "hidden judgments" inside our words. It is also practice in speaking in a "judgment free" manner. [click here to go to this exercise.](#)

Final Day to Join the Certificate of Completion Track

We have received a number of inquiries from participants interested in the track so today is the last day that registrations will be accepted for the Certificate of Completion Track. Sign up now.

For increased structure, accountability and recognition of your work, this year The Compassion Course offers an optional Certificate of Completion (for an additional fee of \$70).

Document your coursework related to weekly readings, exercises and experiences using our secure online platform and database.

Get weekly reminders and helpful hints and advice to help you stay on track.

Have your work confidentially verified* by Compassion Course staff at the end of the course year for certificate qualification.

Pre-qualify to apply for the 2027 Mentor Program

*Verification does not include personal mentoring or feedback. It is specifically to verify that you have completed the work of the course.

Sign up now

If you haven't already, [Click Here to Join the GCN](#)

 Your response · Week 6 · Practice #4

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 7

More About Feelings

Practice #1 — Me and My Feelings

This exercise is an effective way to find the thoughts and reactions you have in relation to your feelings. By doing it, you will create the opportunity to have a deeper relationship with your feelings (and yourself) over time. For now, just notice what happens. This experience might be something you would like to share on our Community Forum, The GCN (Global Compassion Network).

Think of a situation in your life where you experience a fairly high level of stimulation or pain. Notice the feeling. Feel the feeling. Stay with this feeling for a minute or so, simply noticing and feeling your feeling. Stay with it.

You may notice you are judging, avoiding or backing away from this feeling. Notice when this happens. Then go back to feeling your feeling. Repeat. Try this for 2 to 5 minutes.

Your response · Week 7 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Deeper Exploration - Noticing What I Tell Myself About My Feelings

Write down 4 judgments you have about your feelings (for example: "I don't deserve to have them", "they are going to hurt me", and so on).

HINT: You will usually uncover some of these in Practice #1.

Next, write down what need(s) you are meeting, or attempting to meet, by holding these judgments. Take your time.

After that, write down what need(s) you are NOT meeting by holding these judgments. Notice anything? This might also be something you would like to share on the GCN.

Your response · Week 7 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 8

The Wisdom Inside the Judgment

Practice #1 — Start a Judgment Journal

In a journal, write down judgments that you find yourself holding about someone (including yourself).

Later on, when you have time, sit down and write all the judgments you can think of about this person (yes, even if it's you). Have a good go at it. Be specific. Not just that they are "a jerk". What kind of "jerk". A "self-centered jerk"? A "lazy jerk"? The more specific our judgments, the more information we can get about our needs. Weird, but it works.

Then look at the needs list and see if you can figure out what needs your different judgments are telling you about.

Your response · Week 8 · Practice #1

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 9

My Being and My Robot

Practice #1 — Noticing Disconnecting Habitual Thoughts

Find a word or expression that you use every day that may disconnect you from your conscious self: for example, "have to", as in "I have to go to the store" or "I have to do the laundry". Try to notice yourself using those words and then try replacing them with words that more accurately reflect a deeper connection, or that more accurately reflect what is happening in you - like "I've decided to go to the store" or "I'm going to do the laundry".

Perhaps there are other words such as "like" or "really" or "actually" that you use out of habit that, when you think about it, don't really contribute to your message or express what's going on for you. See if you can find another set of words or maybe less words that will accomplish your communication in a more conscious way. Warning - this exercise in noticing our own thoughts can be quite difficult. That said, the skill of noticing our thought habits is essential for creating a more compassionate life. Keep trying!

 Your response · Week 9 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Start or Continue Your Judgment Journal

Try and notice any judgments or other disconnecting habitual (often repetitive) thoughts you have throughout your day and write them down.

Later on, when you have time, read over your journal for the day. Next, check in with yourself about how you feel as you think about those thoughts. Then look at the needs list and wonder what need(s) you are trying to meet (or are meeting) with those thoughts.

Then write down at least one other way that you could possibly meet your need(s) that might leave you more connected or at peace.

 Your response · Week 9 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 10

What Empathy Is... and What It's Not

Practice #1 — Increase Your Awareness

See if you can notice yourself using any of the mentioned "non-empathic", habitual forms of communication. Later, when you have some time and space, see if you can imagine what an "empathic" response would be. What was that person feeling? What was that person needing, wanting to have more of, or yearning to experience? Check the feelings list and the needs list for the answer. Now imagine what you might say.

 Your response · Week 10 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Play the Empathy/Non-Empathy Game

To do this practice, work with a partner in person or on the phone.

Step 1: Write down a quote, something you might say when you would want some empathy, like "I'm feeling really stressed about my finances." Hint — don't pick something too important. You'll understand why very soon.

Step 2: Say your quote to your partner and have them respond with any of the "non-empathic" forms of communication mentioned in this week's message. This could be something like, comparing: "Oh you think your finances are bad? I've been broke for..." or educating: "The way I see it, there's a lesson in this for you" or discounting: "Just relax, you'll be fine" or data gathering: "Tell me exactly when this all started."

Step 3: Try saying the same quote again with your partner giving an empathic response. This could be something like "Are you feeling scared because you need more peace of mind?"

Step 4: Switch roles so that you have both had a chance to receive non-empathic responses and an empathic response that "lands". You'll know it when you hear it.

For this practice, it may be easier to start out with the simplest form of empathy: "Are you feeling _____ (feeling from the feelings list) because you need more _____ (need from the needs list)."

 Your response · Week 10 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 11

Creating Your Life of Compassion

Practice #1 — Reminding and Remembering

Reread our earlier messages. Consider taking this week to repeating some of the practices that you imagine will help you grow.

🔍 Your response · Week 11 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Read or Join the GCN Community Message Forum

For instructions see the information below.

🔍 Your response · Week 11 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — Find an Empathy Buddy

Our Community Forum and Empathy Buddy Forum are great places to post a request to find a buddy.

🔍 Your response · Week 11 · Practice #3

Practice #4 — Join a Practice Group

For information on groups visit the GCN (below) and click the link "Practice Group Calendar"

🔍 Your response · Week 11 · Practice #4

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 12

Slowing Down

Practice #1 — Find Your Moment

Remember a time when you were about to "lose it". Re-visit the moment in your mind. Notice how your body feels, notice the tension or the thoughts that occur in the moments when you are in that place. You may want to journal your experiences as a way to recall and deepen your awareness. Next think of a "cue" that you can give yourself in the future when you find yourself getting upset, a way to give yourself space to ask "What is happening"?

Think of a message or phrase you can say to yourself that helps you find your way off of the super highway of upset and onto the path of compassionate, empathic thought and awareness.

You might consider words like "What is that?" or "Wow, this isn't working" or "This is one of those moments", whatever works for you. The goal is to signal yourself to move to a process of compassionate understanding of yourself and others.

 Your response · Week 12 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Find Your Words

Imagine what you might say to someone when you notice this moment. How could you slow your conversation down and create the vital time and space to connect to the compassion that awaits inside you? For example:

"I really don't want to talk like this. I need to take some time."

"I'm so upset and I don't want to say anything I'll regret, so I'm taking some time to gather myself."

"I love you so much that I really don't want to talk like this. I need some time to think this out."

"I can't think of a way I can respond that's going to help us right now. I need to take a time-out and talk when I'm more centered."

HINTS:

1) Don't ask; tell. If we ask for permission, chances are we won't get it. Often, the other person will encourage us to stay in the conversation. It will likely take some compassionate resolve to create the time and space we need. It is especially hard in the beginning.

2) Practice ahead of time so you have the words you need within your grasp. Make them your words, remembering they are being said to create compassion and connection. Explain this to others. They may thank you later.

3) Let the other person know that you do want to resume. Maybe even provide a time to re-connect. Remember, to the other person "later" can be heard as "never".

 Your response · Week 12 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 13

Requests

Practice #1 — Find Your Moment

Practice(s) for the Week

✎ Your response · Week 13 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Liberate Yourself

Think of a "no" from someone that you are having a hard time hearing (accepting).

Then, write down what need (or needs) of yours you are trying to meet with the request you're hearing "no" to.

Next, write down 3 to 5 ways you could meet your need(s) WITHOUT hearing a "yes" from that person.

✎ Your response · Week 13 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — Compassionate Understanding

After you complete Practice #1, imagine what need(s) the person who said "no" was meeting by saying "no".

✎ Your response · Week 13 · Practice #3

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 14

More about Self-Empathy

Practice #1 — Welcome Your Judgments

Think of a situation that is on your mind. In your mind, let out all the judgments and write them down on a piece of paper. Keep going until you can't think of any more. Then think again. Get them on that paper!

✎ Your response · Week 14 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Feel Your Feelings

After completing Practice #1, bring this same situation to your mind. Notice how you feel as you think about it. Pick the feeling that is the most present.

Then feel that feeling. Stay with it. Take your time [...] Notice.

Are you afraid of the feeling?

Are you judging the feeling?

Are you thinking you "shouldn't" feel that way?

Notice anything that may be stopping you from feeling that feeling... and then go back to feeling the feeling. Continue this process for one or two minutes.

✎ Your response · Week 14 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — Connect to Your Needs

After completing Practice #2, identify a need this feeling is related to.

Then, remember a time in your life when this need was met.

Create a vision in your mind.

What was happening?

Where were you?

What did it feel like?

Stay with this image, like a video in your mind, playing over and over. Bask in it.

Then, after a few minutes, envision a time when someone you know had this need met.

Create a vision in your mind.

What was happening?

Where were you?

What did it feel like to see this?

Stay with this image, like a video in your mind, playing over and over. Bask in this too.

Stay with the need a bit longer. Notice any ideas that occur to you. See if you can think of a request that you might make of yourself or someone else that would move you in the direction of having that need met.

This is a wonderful exercise to share with our community through the GCN. Tell us what happened!
To listen to Thom lead a need-embodiment meditation: [CLICK HERE](#).

 Your response · Week 14 · Practice #3

Reflections & Notes		
Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 15

Connection Requests

Practice #1 — Try for Some Connection

The next time you think your message may not have been received, try asking for a reflection. Remember, if you say, "Could you tell me what you just heard me say?" this could easily be construed as a "test".

If you say something like, "This is really important to me and I want to be sure I've been clear and we're on the same page. Could you tell me what you heard me say?" that is likely to create a different, more connecting experience.

You can also try some of these other requests to build connection:

- 1) "Having heard what I just said, can you tell me what's going on for you?"
- 2) "Would you tell me your understanding of my feelings and needs?"
- 3) "Would you tell me how you're feeling after hearing what I just said?"
- 4) "Would you tell me what comes up for you about what I just said?"
- 5) "May I reflect what I think I'm hearing you say?"
- 6) "May I reflect what I think I heard you say?"

🔍 Your response · Week 15 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Review and Support Yourself

Review Week 13 (go to the GCN to access previous weeks)

🔍 Your response · Week 15 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — Requesting Self-Connection

The next time you feel yourself getting upset, ask yourself, "What am I needing right now and not getting?", or, "What do I love that has me feeling this way?" Yes, as I mentioned earlier, you can make a connection request of yourself too.

🔍 Your response · Week 15 · Practice #3

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 16

Saying 'No' with Compassion - Boundaries

Practice #1 — Try Saying "No"

The next time you are clear that you don't want to do something, check in with yourself and see what needs you would meet by saying "no". Then share this with the other person and share your "no".

For example, you could say, "I'm thinking we're about to get in a fight right now, and I'm going to take a time-out so we can continue in a more connected constructive way." Or

"I'm conflicted. I would really love to go out and have some fun tonight, but I know I really need some rest, so I'm going to pass. Another time, if you'd like, for sure."

 Your response · Week 16 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Saying "No" Do-over

Think of a time when you said "yes" and you really wanted to say "no". Practice how you might say a compassionate "no" next time.

 Your response · Week 16 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — Review and Support Yourself

Review Week 12 (You can find it on the GCN, link below).

 Your response · Week 16 · Practice #3

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 17

Compassionate Use of Force

Practice #1 — Use of Force Do-over

Think of a time when you used punishment in a forceful way. Imagine how you might have been able to approach the situation using a "protective" use of force.

 Your response · Week 17 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Try Something New

The next time you think you need to "punish" someone, think of what you are trying to accomplish. What are you trying to protect? See if you can think of a way to do that without anger in your heart. Think about sharing your story on the GCN.

 Your response · Week 17 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

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Week 18

Beliefs and Needs

Practice #1 — Inventory Your Beliefs

Write down a list of beliefs that you have. For example, "the world is a dangerous place", "the world is a safe place", "people are basically compassionate", "people are basically self-centered", "I am not good enough", "I don't deserve a rewarding relationship," and so on. Really check yourself out. Write them down.

Under each belief, write a list of needs that are met and needs not met by that particular belief.

✎ Your response · Week 18 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Think of a New Belief

After Practice #1, see if you are really getting what you want from your beliefs. Then, if you can find one or more beliefs that are not serving you as well as you would like, try writing down some new beliefs. Make a list of needs that are met and needs not met by these new beliefs too. Consider sharing what comes up for you on the GCN.

Note: This is a practice that can take some time and that we can all engage in for life. It takes repeated practice and it often helps to get support from an empathy buddy. The results are almost always wonderfully life-changing.

✎ Your response · Week 18 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 19

The Art of Observation

Practice #1 — Review the "Shifting to Compassion" Exercise

This time, work with this exercise using observations in addition to, or instead of, quotes. [CLICK HERE](#) to go to the exercise.

 Your response · Week 19 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Distinguishing Evaluations and Judgments

Review from Week 6. This exercise helps us find the "hidden judgment" inside the way we use words. It is also practice in speaking in a "judgment-free" manner. [CLICK HERE](#) to go to this exercise.

New to the GCN? [Click Here to Join](#)

GCN Members [Click Here to Access it](#)

 Your response · Week 19 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 20

Scary Honesty

Practice #1 — Scary Honesty in Action

Think of someone who you care about, who often speaks more than you enjoy. Then, imagine what you could say (compassionately interrupting them) to create more connection in that moment. Consider trying it out for real.

New to the GCN? [Click Here to Join](#)

GCN Members [Click Here to Access it](#)

Your response · Week 20 · Practice #1

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 21

Appreciation from the Heart

Practice #1 — Practice Noticing

Write down a list of five or ten things that are happening and the met needs that you have in this very moment. For example, breathing/air, reading this/learning and growth, sitting in a building/security.

Note: I can not express in these few words, how powerful this practice is. In past years, this has been a pivotal experience for many Compassion Course participants. Consider sharing your experience with this exercise on our Community Forum so that others might understand and perhaps be inspired.

 Your response · Week 21 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Share an Appreciation

Remember something that someone said or did that contributed to your needs being met. Ask them if you could share something that you appreciate with them. Then let them know what happened, how it felt and what need(s) it met.

For example: "I just want to let you know how grateful I am for the help with these dishes. I realize what a difference it makes when we team up like this. It's way more fun, not to mention it goes so much faster when we talk with each other while we're doing it. Thanks." Again, consider sharing your experience with this exercise on our Community Forum.

New to the GCN? [Click Here to Join](#)

GCN Members [Click Here to Access it](#)

 Your response · Week 21 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 22

The Power of Thanks — More About Appreciation

Practice #1 — Check In Again

As we did last time, write down a list of things that are happening and the needs that are being met in this very moment. For example, breathing/air, reading this/learning and growth, sitting in a building/security. This time, write down ten to twenty of them. Then notice how you feel. Pretty cool, right?

✎ Your response · Week 22 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Appreciate Yourself

Write down three ways you contribute to your own life, three things that you do or have done that you enjoy. Then write down the needs you meet for yourself. Then look in the mirror and say, "Thank you."

Note: It is difficult to do this without smiling.

✎ Your response · Week 22 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — Renewed Sharing an Appreciation

Think of something that someone said or did that contributed to your needs being met. Ask them if you could share something you appreciate with them. Then let them know what happened, how it felt and what need (or needs) it met.

"I just want to let you know how much I appreciate your company at the movies last night... and for that matter all the times we've spent together... the friendship, the fun and companionship you bring into my life makes such a difference to me. Thank you, really."

You can do this in person, by phone, through an email, text, or by writing a card.

Note: This can also be done with someone that is no longer in your life or even here on the planet.

✎ Your response · Week 22 · Practice #3

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 23

Apologies Versus Restoration

Practice #1 — "Restoration Preparation"

Think of a situation where you said or did something you regretted and were unable to express yourself in a more connecting way. Perhaps you were feeling too scared or angry with yourself or the other person. Write down how you might say it now, in terms of your own unmet needs. The following steps may help.

1. Observation: Recall an occasion when you did or said something you wish you hadn't, the exact action or quote.
2. Acknowledge your judgments about what you said or did by bringing them out into the light: What are you saying to yourself? Examples: "I'm such an idiot", "I'll never get it", "Why can't I just think fast enough!". "I should have done X".

Note: Many of us have learned to educate ourselves through guilt, shame and other less-than-fun tactics. We can notice this by our feelings of anger or guilt. Words we often use in the process of judging or shaming are almost always some form of "should" or "shouldn't". These words deny choice and disconnect us from ourselves.

3. Look beneath those judgments to see what need is at their root. What unmet need of yours is expressed by the judgment? [maybe care, consideration?]. Also, what need(s) of yours went unmet by the way you behaved? [Examples: respect, connection, etc.]
4. Compassionate Mourning: Meditate on the energy of each need, not the absence of it, what it means to you, why it's so important to you, how you yearn to experience that. If you feel a sweet pain, that is you connecting with your need - pain stimulated by past actions which you now regret. Regret can help us learn from what we have done without blaming or hating ourselves.
5. Write down your what you might say. It might be, "When I (did, said etc.), I would have loved to have shown more _____ (ex. care, consideration, etc.) - I know that had an impact on you and so it's really important to me. Now that I understand this, I would like to deal with that differently in the future, in a way that is more in alignment with my values and creates more _____.

Depending on the situation, we may think about asking for a reflection or say something like, I'm wondering what goes on for you hearing this?

Your response · Week 23 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — "Restoration"

After completing Practice #1, consider contacting the other person and share your words.

Note: Be prepared to empathize with the person's pain, if expressed. You may be tempted to defend or explain your actions. Chances are, your explanations won't be received (for now, that's between you and yourself).

Just empathize.

You may want to share your experience on the GCN.

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Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 24

Hearing 'NO' with Compassion

Practice #1 — Inventory Your Beliefs about "No"

Write down a list of beliefs that you have about what "no" means. For example, "I don't matter", or "People don't love me", or "I don't deserve", or "I'm not good enough" and so on. Write them all down.

Then, make a list of needs that are met and needs that are not met by each belief.

After that, try writing down some new beliefs... like "I value living in a world where people can act from choice", or "A 'no' to my request is not about me; it's a way for people to take care of themselves and I value that", or "Living in a world where I can hear 'no', makes my life more wonderful". Make a list of needs that are met and needs that are not met by these new beliefs. Consider sharing what comes up for you on our Community Forum.

✎ Your response · Week 24 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — (Repeated from Week 13) Liberate Yourself

Think of a "no" from someone that you are having a hard time hearing.

Then, write down what need (or needs) of yours you are trying to meet with the request you're hearing no to.

Then, write down 3 to 5 ways you could meet that (or those) need(s) without hearing a yes from that person.

✎ Your response · Week 24 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — (Repeated from Week 13) Compassionate Understanding

After you complete Practice #1, imagine what need (or needs) the person who is saying "no" is trying to meet by saying "no".

✎ Your response · Week 24 · Practice #3

Practice #4 — Requesting Self-Connection

The next time you ask yourself to do something and then don't do it (yes, you can say "no" to yourself too), ask yourself, "What need(s) am I trying to meet by asking myself to do this?" Write them down.

Then, ask yourself, "What need(s) am I meeting by not doing this?" With this perspective, see if you can figure out if there's another way you could meet both these sets of needs. Perhaps you could do several things, or nothing.

Share your process on the GCN or with an empathy buddy. See if you can get empathy or strategies from others. Remember, "If you want to travel far, go with others."

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 Your response · Week 24 · Practice #4

Reflections & Notes		
Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 25

Living a Life of Compassion

Practice #1 — Review and Renew

Go back to Chapters 1 through 4 and choose two or three practices to renew.

Week 1 - Everything We Do, We Do to Meet a Need

Week 2 - Most of Us Were Taught Something Else

Week 3 - We Are All Equipped with Onboard Need Radar

Week 4 - What's the Big Deal with Needs?

Your response · Week 25 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Let's Inspire One Another

Join or post on our Community Forum (it's not too late). Consider sharing any stories or experiences you have had pursuing your life of compassion.

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Your response · Week 25 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 26

Clarity About Judgments

Practice #1 — Review and Renew

Go back to Chapters 2, 6 and 8 and choose two or three practices to renew.

✎ Your response · Week 26 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Create Some Clarity

See if you can remember and write down an example of 1) a moralistic judgment you have 2) a value-oriented judgment you have and 3) an assessment you have. Next, write down:

a) The need(s) that your moralistic judgment is telling you that you value.

and

b) What need you are attempting to meet by having this judgment.

✎ Your response · Week 26 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — More Clarity

For each of these judgments write two lists. One of all the needs that are met with it and another of those not met (if any) with it.

Note: I can not express in these few words, how powerful this practice is. In past years, this has been a pivotal experience for many of the Compassion Course participants. Consider sharing your experience with this exercise on the GCN so that others might understand and perhaps be inspired.

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✎ Your response · Week 26 · Practice #3

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 27

Connecting to Life Energy

Practice #1 — Review and Renew

Go back and reread Chapters 3 and 7.

📝 Your response · Week 27 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Feel Your Feelings (From Week #7)

Think of a situation in your life where you experience a fairly high level of stimulation or pain. Notice the feeling. Feel the feeling. Stay with this feeling for a few moments. Simply notice and feel this feeling. Stay with it.

You may notice you are judging, avoiding, rationalizing or backing away from this feeling. Notice when this happens... breathe... gently, go back to feeling your feeling. Repeat. Try this for 2 to 5 minutes.

This exercise is an effective way to see how we think about our feelings. It is also an opportunity to deepen our relationship with them (and ourselves) over time. For now, just notice what happens in the coming days. As time passes, share any notable experiences you may have on our Community Forum.

📝 Your response · Week 27 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — Embody a Need

You may want to find some quiet space and time for this exercise. Start by going to the NEEDS LIST and find a need that is important to you, perhaps a need that you would like to experience more "metness" of.

Next, sit back and make yourself comfortable. Close your eyes. Feel your breath.

Now, in your mind's eye, remember a time when that need was met. "Relive" this experience in your mind. Remember where you were, who was there, what was happening... Remember what it felt like. Slow it down. Replay this moment over and over in your mind. Let the feeling of the experience into your body.

Bask in the moment. Bask in the memory, in the feeling.

When you are feeling full or "complete" in this practice, open your eyes. Notice what is happening inside you as you think about this need.

Consider reviewing the following embodiment meditation from my podcast: [CLICK HERE](#).

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📝 Your response · Week 27 · Practice #3

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 28

The Layering of Needs

Practice #1 — Shifting Toward Compassion Redo

First, begin the "Shifting Toward Compassion" exercise at: <http://theexercise.org>.

When you are done listing your needs in the first section, review the needs you have listed. As you read each one, ask yourself:

"What need (or needs) might be met if I met this need?"

If you can think of any, add them to your list.

Next, ask yourself:

"What need (or needs) would I want to meet in order to get this need met?"

If you can think of any, add them to your list.

Then complete the exercise.

Notice how this changes your experience of "The Exercise". See if you can think of requests that might contribute to your need(s) being met. (See Practice #2 below.)

Share your experience on our Community Forum or Facebook Page.

Your response · Week 28 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Review and Renew

Go back and reread Weeks 3, 7, 13 and 15.

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Your response · Week 28 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 29

Self-Connection

Practice #1 — Learn to Get Your Own Attention

Keep a small journal with you throughout the day. Make 1 to 3 entries per day, at times when you notice you are feeling some form of unfulfilled feeling or pain.

When you notice the feeling, ask yourself, "What is that?" Then write down what just happened. Was it something that someone did or something someone said? Was it a thought you had?

Either at that time, or later on, write down a word (or words) from the feelings list that describes your feeling.

Then look at the needs list and see if you can figure out what need(s) your feeling is telling you about.

Having this level of awareness throughout your day can be a challenge and you may experience some frustration or surprise in your attempts. Just remember, these feelings (of frustration or surprise) can help you remember to do this ... sooner or later.

You will most likely find that the more you do this, the more natural it seems and the more proficient you will become. This process is you, getting your own attention - becoming centered in your needs, becoming centered in life.

Consider sharing your experience on our Community Forum.

 Your response · Week 29 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Take It to the Next Level

After you have completed Practice #1, see if you can think of any requests you can make that would contribute to the need(s) you have identified.

If you're practicing this for the first time, it may feel like things are moving very quickly. It can also feel scary, like you're taking your first solo flight. You are! This is the practice of compassionate living.

 Your response · Week 29 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — Review

Review Weeks 3 & 4 about "Feelings" and "Needs", as well as Weeks 13 & 15 on "Requests" and "Connection Requests".

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 Your response · Week 29 · Practice #3

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 30

Enjoying Pain

Practice #1 — Moving from Anger to Pain

Think of a situation where you are experiencing some anger. As mentioned before, starting with lower levels of stimulation works best.

Once you have it in your mind, check in with yourself - feel into your body. See if you can find some sadness or fear (or other unfulfilled feelings). Feel that feeling for a few moments. Just stay with it.

If you have difficulty with this, you may want to go back to the "Practices" in Week 7.

Next, ask yourself what need or needs you would like to have met that are not. This may be a good time to connect with your needs through mourning or embodiment (See Week 27).

Later, after some time has passed, see if you can think of three ways to get those needs met that do not depend on the situation that you started with.

Your response · Week 30 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Un-numbing

Keep a small journal next to your bed. When you first wake up in the morning, write down the first feeling or feelings you notice. Do you have any unfulfilled feelings? Even tiny ones? Repeat this exercise until you identify any consistent unfulfilled feeling or feelings you may experience. Then, get or give yourself empathy about these feeling(s). See what you notice, including any requests you might make of yourself or others. Consider sharing your experience on our Community Forum.

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Your response · Week 30 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 31

Shift versus Compromise

Practice #1 — Moving from Compromise to a Shift

Think of situation where you think you have to compromise.

Go to "The Exercise" at <http://theexercise.org> and follow the format of the two "T"s, starting with your observation (as opposed to a quote) and writing down your feelings and needs and the other person's feelings and needs.

See if you experience a "shift" or can think of requests you might make (see Week 13 and Week 15).

Your response · Week 31 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Deeper Practice

The next time you find yourself in a conflict, see if you can self-empathize and then empathize with the other person.

To do this, you may have to "slow down" (see Week 12) to get to your center and be in a position to empathize with the other person and create a dialog to discover each others' feelings and needs.

See if you can get to a place of mutual, compassionate understanding, where you both understand each other's feeling and needs. Then, see if you can think of a way to resolve your conflict without compromise. Consider sharing what happens on our Community Forum.

NOTE: Practice #2 requires the agreement of both parties to participate - both parties must want to resolve the conflict and take mutual responsibility and care to see it through (no small thing). That said, the rewards are almost always worth the time and energy.

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Your response · Week 31 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 32

Stimulus versus Cause

Practice #1 — Changing Focus

Think of a situation where you think someone is causing you some pain or dissatisfaction. Write down the "stimulus" (their action or actions).

Next, write down your feelings and needs (the cause). Then, see if you can figure out how your need(s) might be met by changing your actions.

 Your response · Week 32 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Changing Focus Again

Think of situation where you think you are causing yourself some pain or dissatisfaction. Write down the "stimulus" (your action or actions).

Next, write down your feelings and needs (the cause). Then, see if you can figure out how your need(s) might be met by changing your actions or making a request of yourself or others (see Week 13 and Week 15).

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 Your response · Week 32 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 33

Understanding Anger

Practice #1 — Dismantling Anger

Think of a situation where you are experiencing anger in any of its forms (annoyance, indignation, outrage, etc.). Write down your observation. See Week 6 and Week 19 for help with this.

Next, write down your judgment thoughts, all of them... thoughts that describe what you might be thinking this person should or shouldn't be doing or thoughts about "what is wrong with them".

After that, see if you can identify some other feelings besides anger, like frustration, fear or sadness and write them down too.

Next, see if you can identify your unmet needs and write them down as well.

Finally, see if you can figure out how your need(s) might be met by changing your thoughts or actions.

Note: This is a wonderful exercise to do with the assistance of an empathy buddy.

Your response · Week 33 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Heavy Lifting - Dismantling Anger and Making Requests

Go through Practice #1. This time, think of a request you might make to begin a dialog with the other person, that you can hear "no" to and still be OK (see Week 13 and Week 15). Hint: If you do actually make a request, starting with a "connection request" usually helps. Understanding what is alive in the other person will make a big difference if you want to experience a connection and communicate clearly and compassionately.

[Click Here for Sample Connection Requests.](#)

Note: This is VERY challenging work. Approach it with love and care for all involved and be prepared to "slow down". See Week 12 for help with this.

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Your response · Week 33 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 34

Being Responsive versus Being Responsible

Practice #1 — Moving from Responsible to Responsive

Think of a situation where you have been thinking that you are responsible for someone's anger. Write it down.

Next, give yourself (or better yet receive) empathy for what is alive in you about this situation. After some time and empathy, you may become curious about the other person's experience and want more understanding and connection with them. If so, proceed. If not so, continue receiving empathy (all things in their own time).

Next, see if you can connect with that person's pain. Write down your best understanding of what it might be like for them. Not their thoughts - their feelings, their pain. The needs of theirs that are unmet and how important those needs must be to them.

Note: You may be thinking "I don't really know what they're experiencing". I suggest that doesn't stop us from wondering, or even imagining, what it might be like for them. In my experience, it's the process of wondering that brings the compassion and the connection, not a precise depiction.

This can be a very powerful exercise if we use our skills of slowing down, translating judgments, seeing and connecting to feelings and needs (embodiment, mourning).

Finally, see if you can imagine any connection requests you might make. (Hint for this: See Week 15. Ask yourself, "What would Harpo do?").

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Your response · Week 34 · Practice #1

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 35

Acting Angry versus Being Angry versus Consciously Feeling Anger

Practice #1 — Noticing

Keep a small journal with you throughout the day. Make 1 to 5 entries per day that include a description of situations where you felt some anger - even a little bit, where you may have been annoyed or miffed or irked. Include any judgment words you were thinking. Just practice noticing. This is the window to "conscious anger".

 Your response · Week 35 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Stepping into Awareness

Later on, when you have time, sit down with the needs list and see if you can figure out what need(s) you were in pain about. Translate your judgment words into need words. As usual, I suggest that you limit the words you use to those on the needs list. Write them down.

Then, write down any other needs that you notice you were hoping to have met in that situation that were not met.

This is a great time to get some help from an empathy partner.

Finally, write down three different requests you might make of yourself or others (see Week 13 and Week 15).

 Your response · Week 35 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — Get Support

If you have not visited or participated in our Community Forum, it's not too late. Directions to join are below.

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 Your response · Week 35 · Practice #3

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 36

Surfing Intensity

Practice #1 — Your Anger Redo

Think of a situation when you were angry in reaction to something someone did or said, where you would have liked to experience more connection. Then write down what you were thinking, feeling and needing, including:

- 1) Your moralistic judgments;
- 2) Your anger-related feelings like annoyed, pissed, furious, mad, outraged, livid;
- 3) Your should/shouldn't judgments (what they should or shouldn't have done);
- 4) Your non-anger feelings like frustrated, fearful, sad, confused;
- 5) Your needs (your own life energy and what you would love to experience);

 Your response · Week 36 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Their Anger Redo

Think of a situation when someone was angry in reaction to something you did or said, where you would have liked to experience more connection. Then write down what you imagine they were thinking, feeling and needing, including:

- 1) Their moralistic judgments;
- 2) Their anger-related feelings like annoyed, pissed, furious, mad, outraged, livid;
- 3) Their should/shouldn't judgments (what you should or shouldn't have done);
- 4) Their non-anger feelings like frustrated, fearful, sad, confused;
- 5) Their needs (their own life energy and what they would love to experience);

Finally, write down what you might say to them to create more connection, in light of your inquiry about these thoughts, feelings and needs.

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 Your response · Week 36 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 37

Compassionate Intensity

Practice #1 — Yell Out to Yourself

Think of a situation where you are experiencing some intense feeling and need, where you would like to express this experience in a self-connected way and express your intensity.

Next, fully self-empathize. Write down what you are thinking, feeling and needing, including:

- 1) If needed - your moralistic judgments.
- 2) If needed - your anger related feelings like annoyed, furious, mad, outraged, livid.
- 3) Your should/shouldn't judgments (what should have happened).
- 4) Your non-anger feelings like frustrated, fearful, sad, confused.
- 5) Your needs (your own life energy and what you would love to experience).

Now go to a mirror. Look yourself in the eye and yell out your pain (the feelings and needs you have identified in #4 and #5 above). For example, "I'm just so frustrated! Why can't this just be easier?! I need a break! I'm at the end of my rope!" In this exercise, see if you can notice when you are in judging mode versus pain mode (they feel different). Practice, practice, practice, until you can align your intensity with your heart.

Your response · Week 37 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Yell Out to a Friend

Go through Practice #1, only this time practice with a friend or empathy buddy (preferably who is not directly involved in your pain) and get their feedback. See if they can spot your judgments. If you "slip into judgment mode", try again.

If they see or hear judgments that you are sure you are not holding, practice generating more clarity that you are simply screaming your pain. This may require some empathy.

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Your response · Week 37 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 38

Words and Thoughts That Fuel Anger and Deny Choice

Practice #1 — Make Your Life More Wonderful

Think of a situation where you think you "should have" or "shouldn't have" done or said something.

Next, write down the need(s) you were trying to meet with this "should/shouldn't" thought. Was it inspiration? Maybe effectiveness? Keep guessing until you guess it.

After that, write down what need(s) your should/shouldn't thought is telling you about. What is it that you value so much? What need is that?

Then, write down the needs you were meeting by doing something else.

Try keeping all the needs in your awareness for a while - focusing on just the needs - no particular strategy. This could be done for minutes or days. You can write them down and put them on a mirror or other conspicuous place. Notice what comes up. This can be a very powerful exercise if you stay with it.

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Your response · Week 38 · Practice #1

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 39

Agreements versus Rules

Practice #1 — Rule Redo

Think of a situation where you are following a rule, or expecting someone else to follow a rule, and you are experiencing some pain.

Next, write down the need(s) you are trying to meet with this rule (safety, effectiveness, etc.).

After that, write down what needs or values are not expressed by this rule or by adhering to it.

Finally, check in with yourself to see if you might think differently about the situation. See if you can think of different ways to meet all these needs... perhaps by eliminating this rule or changing it to an agreement through a dialog or self-empathy.

 Your response · Week 39 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Agreement Redo

Think of a situation where you are keeping an agreement, or expecting someone else to keep an agreement, and you are experiencing some pain.

Next, write down the need(s) you are trying to meet with this agreement (partnership, care, etc.).

After that, write down what needs or values are not met by this agreement or by adhering to it.

Then, see if you can think of ways to change this agreement to meet all these needs.

Finally, if you think you are ready, speak with the person you have this agreement with, and see if you can create a deeper understanding of everyone's needs and come to a new agreement that considers and meets more needs.

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 Your response · Week 39 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 40

The Art of Mourning

Practice #1 — Connecting with Feelings and Needs

Think of a situation in your life where you are experiencing some discomfort, or pain.

Next, check into your body and focus on what you're feeling. See if you can bring that feeling into clearer awareness. Invite it to the surface. Feel the feeling. Stay with this feeling for a few moments - simply noticing and feeling this feeling. Again, stay with it - at least for 60 seconds, longer if possible.

You may notice you are judging, avoiding or backing away from this feeling. Acknowledge when this happens. Then go back to the feeling. Repeat. Try this for 2 to 5 minutes.

If necessary, repeat this practice over the next week until you connect to the need(s) this feeling is telling you about.

Repeat separately for each feeling you identify.

Your response · Week 40 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Embodying Needs

Need-embodiment meditation:

FULL LENGTH AUDIO VERSION [CLICK HERE](#).

Or Follow below:

You may want to find some quiet space and time for this practice. Practice this separately with each need that you would like to experience more "metness" of (from Practice #1).

Sit back and make yourself comfortable. Close your eyes. Feel your breath - Relax.

Now, in your mind's eye, remember a time when that need was met. "Relive" this experience in your mind. Remember where you were, who was there, what was happening - Remember what it felt like. Slow it down. Replay this moment over and over in your mind. Let the feeling of the experience into your body.

Bask in the moment. Bask in the memory, especially in the feeling of it.

When you are feeling full or "complete" in this practice, open your eyes and come back into your space.

Repeat this exercise with all the needs you have identified from Practice #1 .

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Your response · Week 40 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 41

Enemy Images

Practice #1 — Changing Your Focus

Think of a situation where you believe that someone is preventing you from getting your need(s) fulfilled - where you believe that if their needs are met, yours won't be. Next, write down your feelings and the need(s) you would like (or love) to have fulfilled in this situation.

After you have identified the need(s), go to Practice #2 and embody the need(s) you are now aware of.

 Your response · Week 41 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Embodying Needs (intentionally repeated from last week)

You may want to find some quiet space and time for this practice. Practice this separately with each need that you would like to experience more "metness" of (from Practice #1).

Sit back and make yourself comfortable. Close your eyes. Feel your breath... Relax.

Now, in your mind's eye, remember a time when that need was met. "Relive" this experience in your mind. Remember where you were, who was there, what was happening - Remember what it felt like. Slow it down. Replay this moment over and over in your mind. Let the feeling of the experience into your body.

Bask in the moment. Bask in the memory, especially in the feeling of it.

When you are feeling full or "complete" in this practice, open your eyes and come back into your space.

Repeat this exercise with all the needs you have identified from Practice #1.

To listen to Thom guiding a need-embodiment meditation: [CLICK HERE](#).

 Your response · Week 41 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — Expanding

See if you can imagine 3 ways each of the need(s) that you embodied in Practice #2 might be met by changing your actions or by making a request of yourself or others (see Week 13 and Week 15).

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 Your response · Week 41 · Practice #3

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 42

Power With versus Power Over

Practice #1 — Power Over Redo

Think of situation where you have used your power over someone. Next, write down the need(s) you were trying to fulfill in this situation.

Then, write down the need(s) you did not fulfill in this situation.

Next, embody all these needs (see Week 41). Take your time.

Finally, see if you can imagine a way all these needs might have been met by making a request (of yourself or others) that would have included the other person's power (see Week 13 and Week 15).

Your response · Week 42 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Power With Transformation

Think of situation where you are using your power over someone.

Next, write down your feelings, and the need(s) you are trying to fulfill in this situation as well as the need(s) you are not fulfilling in this situation.

Next, embody all these needs (see Week 41).

Finally, see if you can imagine a new way these needs might be met by changing your actions or making a request that includes the other person's power (see Week 13 and Week 15).

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Your response · Week 42 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 43

Compassionate Self-Discipline

Practice #1 — Compassionate Self-Discipline Redo

Think of situation where you are using should/shouldn't thinking to achieve something in your life. It's helpful to start with something small. It can be something that you are currently doing and not enjoying, or something you have been unsuccessfully trying to achieve.

Then, write down your "should/shouldn't" thought(s).

Next, "translate" your should/shouldn't thoughts to discover the needs that you would love to have met.

Next notice your feelings. See if you can figure out all the need(s) these feelings are trying to tell you about. Write them down.

Note: This might be a great time to get some help from an empathy partner. Sometimes, two hearts are better than one.

At this point, you may want to "embody" some or all of these needs (see Week 41).

Finally, see if you have a different perspective about your actions or if there are any requests you would like to make of yourself or others (see Week 13 and Week 15).

Consider sharing your experience on our Community Forum.

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Your response · Week 43 · Practice #1

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 44

Habitual Authority versus Life-Connected Authority

Practice #1 — Transforming Authority

Think of situation in your life where you have "habitual authority" and would like to experience more connection. It could be in your role as a parent, a teacher, a spouse, a supervisor or a project leader.

Note: The next steps can take quite a bit of time and effort. Getting through them is much easier and more likely to happen with some help from an empathy partner.

Identify and write down the feelings you have about the situation and the need(s) met, as well as the need(s) that are not being met in this situation.

Next, write down the need(s) you imagine the other person is trying to fulfill in this situation, as well as the need(s) they may not have fulfilled in this situation.

At this point, you may want to "embody" some of these needs (see Week 41). Again, this may take some time.

Finally, see if you can imagine new ways these needs might be met, by changing your actions or making requests that consider both your own and the other person's needs (see Week 13, Week 1 and Week 42).

You may want to see if you can transform any "rules" that you are living with into agreements (through dialog or empathy), as a way of meeting more needs (see Week 39).

This might be a great time to get some help from an empathy partner. Sometimes, two hearts are better than one.

At this point, you may want to "embody" some or all of these needs (see Week 41).

Finally, see if you have a different perspective about your actions or if there are any requests you would like to make of yourself or others (see Week 13 and Week 15).

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Your response · Week 44 · Practice #1

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 45

Compassion and Vulnerability

Practice #1 — "Vulnerability Test Flight"

This exercise is challenging. It is recommended that you try the last two steps as a "role-play" with a friend or empathy buddy at least once (if not 10 times) before you try it for real.

So again, steps 1 through 4 are done alone and steps 5 and 6 are the "role-play" or "real-play" parts.

1. Observation: Think of a situation where you did or said something you regret, where you were unable to express yourself in a "vulnerable" way... where you would have liked a deeper connection. Perhaps you were feeling too scared of being judged by yourself or the other person or you were afraid there would be punishment or retribution.

Recall the exact action or quote and write it down.

2. Identify Your Self-Judgments: Write down your judgments about what you did. Bring them out into the light. What are you saying to yourself? For example: "I was so mean"; "that was so inconsiderate"; "I should have done X".

Remember, we often try to educate ourselves through guilt, shame and other less-than-fun tactics. We can notice this by our feelings of anger or guilt. One of the words we often use in this process is "should".

3. Translating Judgments to Needs: Look beneath your judgments to see what unmet need of yours is expressed by each judgment (see Weeks 2 and 8). What needs of yours were not met by the way you behaved or by what you said? For example: "respect" or "connection". Write them down.

4. Self-Compassion: Ask yourself what needs you were trying to meet in the action or words you chose to say or do. Give yourself the gift of compassionate understanding. Write a message to yourself like:

"I understand why I did that. I was trying to meet my needs for _____, _____ and _____. And even though I understand that, I would love to meet those needs in a way that is more in alignment with my other needs for _____, _____ and _____.

5. Share Your Vulnerability: Imagine how you might share your vulnerability in light of this understanding. Again, try this in a role-play with a practice partner before you try this for real.

It might sound like, "I'm feeling a bit scared sharing this with you because I'm afraid of being judged, but I really want to reconnect. When I (did, said etc.), I didn't meet my need for _____ (ex. care, consideration, ...), and that is really important to me because I know it had an impact on you. Now that I realize this, I would like to deal with that differently, in a way that is more in alignment with my values and creates more _____. I'm wondering what goes on for you hearing this?"

6. Empathize: This is when we are the most vulnerable... where we may want to defend or explain our actions. This is the transformative moment, when we can (through being grounded in our awareness of needs) empathize with the other person's pain, if they choose to share it. This is where our strength to be compassionate will be tested. Just empathize and connect. I have found out the hard way, that defending or explaining are almost always counterproductive in these kinds of conversations and can quickly refresh the pain. For me, in the beginning I found it challenging and imperative to only empathize with the other person's pain - and maybe even translate their judgments without explaining "my side". Vulnerable and powerful.

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Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 46

Demanding versus Persevering

Practice #1 — Liberate Yourself

Think of a "no" that you are, or have been, hearing. It could be from another person, from yourself or from a circumstance in your life.

Then, write down what need (or needs) of yours you are trying to meet as you are hearing this "no".

Then, write down 10 to 15 other ways you might meet that (or those) need(s) while still hearing that "no".

Your response · Week 46 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Persist

Think of at least two connection requests that you might make to find out if each of the strategies you thought of "might work". Yes, this could be a total 30 requests.

[Click Here for Sample Connection Requests.](#)

In persisting we are fine to hear "no" and can often experience a great sense of choice and abundance as we act on our own behalf with passion and compassion.

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Your response · Week 46 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 47

A Compassionate View of Triggers

Practice #1 — Finding Your Triggers

Think of a repeating event (or events) in your life where you experience a reaction that seems disproportionate to you, an upset. Then, write down the answers to the following questions:

What is the triggering event? (You can write this as an observation or in the form of a judgment.)

When does it happen?

How does it happen?

Does it happen with a particular person?

What childhood experience(s) does it remind you of?

 Your response · Week 47 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Working with Your Trigger

This is a great exercise to do with an empathy buddy. You may want to start with "smaller" less intense triggers if possible and then work your way up to more intense situations.

- 1) In writing, describe a time when you were upset (triggered).
- 2) Write down your judgments or the story you are telling yourself about this event.
- 3) Give yourself empathy or get empathy to identify your feelings and needs in regard to this situation or story.
- 4) Describe the trigger in pure observation.
- 5) Give yourself empathy or get empathy again to identify your feelings and needs in this present moment.
- 6) Connect with the need or needs you have identified by embodying them (see Practice #2 in Week 27).
- 7) Take a few minutes to breathe and think about your experience.
- 8) See if you have a different perspective about the way these needs show up in your life or if you can think of any requests you might make of yourself or others.

Note: This is a great exercise to share on our Community Forum. We have about one month left to connect. Sharing our experiences helps us all make life more wonderful.

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 Your response · Week 47 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 48

Pervasive Feelings

Practice #1 — Noticing Small Feelings

In a journal, write down how you feel during three uneventful occasions throughout the day. Do this for two or three days. Choose "uneventful" moments. Look for subtle occurrences: someone sneezing, someone saying "I'm next," you saying "thanks" and so on.

This practice helps increase our awareness of feelings by proactively noticing them. Many of us wait until we are "hit over the head" with a feeling before we notice it. By developing the "muscle" of noticing more feelings, we create more opportunities to make our lives more wonderful.

Your response · Week 48 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Noticing "Pervasive Feelings"

For the next week keep a small journal by your bedside. As you awaken, check in with yourself, see if you notice any feelings moving into your body and write them down.

Next, if you notice you are experiencing a pervasive feeling, see if you can connect it to a pervasive need. This step may be more easily accomplished with the support of an empathy buddy.

Finally, if you are able to find the need(s), see if you can think of a request or requests you might make of yourself or others (see Weeks 13 and 15) to address them.

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Your response · Week 48 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 49

Campaigns

Practice #1 — Needs Assessment Exercise

CLICK HERE to go to the "Needs Assessment Sheet" and follow the instructions. Take your time.

Next, see if you can identify unmet needs that you haven't been aware of, that are important to you, that you would like to act on... even if you don't know how to at this time. Write them down.

Note: It is helpful to look for needs with low "metness" numbers on the left and high "importance" numbers on the right.

Your response · Week 49 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Keep Your Needs in Front of You

Pick the top three needs that you would like to experience more metness of. Write them on a piece of paper and post it in a place where you will see it every day (bathroom mirror, refrigerator, a door, etc.). If you want to have some fun with this, you can get creative (make collages, laminate it, do some drawing).

Identify the need(s) you would have to meet first, in order to meet the original three needs you've identified. Over time (no rush, just keep the list in sight), see if you can think of a request or requests you might make of yourself or others (see Weeks 13 and 15). Continue this practice until your life gets more wonderful.

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Your response · Week 49 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 50

Speaking Your Compassion

Practice #1 — Practice Your Street Empathy

This exercise works well with a partner, although you can practice it on your own too.

First, write down something that someone said to you to express some pain or unmet need. Then, write down the feelings and needs that you imagine they were experiencing. Then, write down a response that encapsulates or expresses these feelings and needs without actually saying the feeling or need words themselves.

For example: Someone said, "I'm having a crazy week. I can't find time to do anything for myself." Ask yourself - are they frustrated, overwhelmed, stressed out? Do they need balance, space, support? What might you say that would reflect your understanding without using those words?

If you can find a partner to do this with, like an empathy buddy, you can experiment with different phrases and see how they "land".

✎ Your response · Week 50 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Practice Your Street Empathy Again

This exercise also works well with a partner, although you can practice on your own too.

First, write down something that someone said to you that expressed some joy or celebration, a met need. Then, write down the feelings and needs that you imagine they are experiencing. Then, write down a response that encapsulates or expresses these feelings and needs without actually saying the feeling or need words themselves.

For example: Someone said, "I'm so happy to finally get some time to myself this weekend." Are they surprised, psyched, jazzed, relieved? Are they getting needs met for balance, space, fun, choice? What might you say that would reflect your understanding without using those words?

As in Practice #1, if you can find a partner to do this with, like an empathy buddy, you can experiment with different phrases and see how they "land".

Note: Last year, folks had a lot of fun with this in our forum. Got some "Street Compassion" you'd like to share?

✎ Your response · Week 50 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — Plan B - Getting Transparent

Think of someone in your life with whom you would like to experience more connection and yet feel awkward speaking to in pure feeling and need words.

Get Centered - Give yourself (or get) some empathy about why you would like to speak with them in feeling and need words and also why you are feeling awkward to do so. In other words, get grounded in your needs.

Be Transparent - Explain why you would like to use feeling and need words. Ask what goes on for them hearing your desire. Be prepared to give them empathy and be clear on your willingness to hear "no" to your strategy of using those words (see Week 13 and Week 15).

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 Your response · Week 50 · Practice #3

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 51

Compassion As a Spiritual Practice

Practice #1 — Appreciating Life

This exercise works well if done in solitude, with one or more objects to bring some beauty to the space (a candle, some incense, a picture of someone you love, a flower, or anything else that brings you a sense of beauty). First, write down 10 things that life is giving you right now. For example, these things might be people, air, a beating heart, comfort, love, food in your stomach, your stomach, your eyes, your sense of smell, your nose, your brain, your mother, your children, your ability to think or read... and so forth.

Then write down all the different needs that these things meet.

Next, read through your two lists (things and needs).

Finally, close your eyes and scan your body. If you feel some appreciation, simply say or think, "Thank you." Read through your list again and repeat this process for 2 or 3 minutes. Notice what happens inside you.

 Your response · Week 51 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Contributing to Life

Over the next week, create at least one way, each day, to consciously contribute to life.

This can be donating money to a life-serving organization, watering a plant, opening a door for someone, smiling at a child (or an adult), telling someone to "keep the change", removing a bug from your home instead of killing it, giving someone flowers or their favorite treat, eating something that is healthy, telling someone what you appreciate about who they are or what they have done (see Weeks 20 and 21 for this last one).

Notice that you are serving life. Notice what happens inside you.

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 Your response · Week 51 · Practice #2

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week

Week 52

Living With Compassion

Practice #1 — Practice, Practice

I invite you to share another year of learning and practicing compassion. As you are reading this, we are in the midst of thousands of folks from around the world signing up for the 2024 Compassion Course. I can only imagine they will benefit from your support and companionship. I can only imagine you will too. (To register, [CLICK HERE](#)).

 Your response · Week 52 · Practice #1

Practice #2 — Practice, Practice, Practice

Find or create a group of like-hearted folks to learn and practice with. Creating support in this way is invaluable. Find some friends to join you in this course to learn and practice together. You can also find trainings at www.nycnvc.org.

 Your response · Week 52 · Practice #2

Practice #3 — Dream...

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 Your response · Week 52 · Practice #3

Reflections & Notes

Insights	A real-life situation I approached in a new way	My intentions for next week